



➔ virus for such platforms is more challenging. Windows was a haven for malware but Windows 8 will change that, slowly. Not now, but maybe 5-10 years down the line viruses of today will be as irrelevant as the DOS prompt. An experimental OS like Firefox OS and Chrome OS will not allow malware to ever enter a system. Based on web-apps, such operating systems will simply block apps (websites in this case) that are malicious.

What will anti-virus companies do? Who knows? Malware has evolved and will probably continue to evolve forever. There will always be servers and workstations, consumer hardware will evolve to nothing more than a “browser”; a window, a thin-client of sorts that connects to the powerful backend that will support such a network. There will always be a requirement for a security suite, but maybe the average consumer can be saved the hassle of ever needing one as these suites just settle in the background, silently keeping the world chugging along from the sidelines.

The dark side

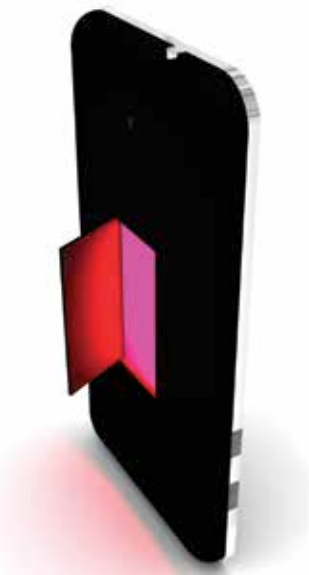
Malware will have to evolve to something more than what it is at the moment. Mobile phones and tablets maybe the future of PCs, but they're also really underpowered and such tightly controlled environments that getting a foothold and creating a botnet of a million PCs will die out because their probably won't be several million PCs to begin with.

Malware will have to be more surreptitious, hitting servers, network connections, extract information, id theft, etc. As you read in the previous section on SSL/TSL, malware will slowly move up the line, moving from consumers to the real hardware that runs the internet and the world. Stakes will be higher, so will the rewards.

Who knows, we might have veritable virtual mafias running around holding the world's data at ransom. Anonymous will seem like a couple of hopped up teenagers in comparison.

Wireless security

Wi-Fi will be the backbone of the future and wireless routers will be what hold this future in place. If malware does move away from traditional PCs, it'll be the vast quantities of precious data that these devices carry that will be the targets. Wireless security as it stands today is sufficient for our needs. Currently, the most popular wireless security protocols are WPA and WPA 2. These are cryptography



A secure OS can do nothing for a compromised network

techniques that are quite secure at the moment and don't look like they need an overhaul anytime soon. The weak link in this chain is, as always, the user.

My precious

Our gadgets are our most prized possessions. In an increasingly mobile world, these portable devices are our lives, our work and our entertainment. Living without that sleek ultrabook / tablet / phablet / phone is something that we can't even imagine. A lost device will have us howling as pitifully as Gollum when he discovers the loss of his coveted ring. We turn into feral beasts who'll do anything to find our device and rip apart the house in an effort to find it, all the while cursing the orcish boor who had the nerve to steal or misplace your precious device.

What do you do in such a situation? Run around squawking like a flustered chicken or unleash a guttural roar of vengeance? Once your device is stolen or “misplaced” there really is nothing much that you can do about it. Certain device such as iPhones and certain Windows phones do come with recovery services and they do work, but with so many devices on the market, not everything is secure.

Laptops were a real sore point when it came to security as there is still almost no way that you can recover a laptop once it's lost or stolen. More importantly, your data might be lost forever and worse still, might end up in the wrong hands.

Intel had come up with a very novel solution to this problem, its integrated anti-theft mechanism. Unlike other anti-theft solutions that just run at a software level, Intel's solution is designed to work at the hardware-level. To simplify the workings a bit, the system uses a key generated at a hardware-level that communicates with a server on an encrypted channel, a channel that the OS itself has no access to. The user pays a service provider to access that server, the service provider could be any one of Intel's trusted partners including McAfee, Norton, etc. What this does is that it gives the user direct, backdoor access into his PC. Unfortunately, for whatever reason, this did not gain much traction among the users at large and Intel is slowly phasing out anti-theft in its current form. While the system did fail, it shows that an innovative system for anti-theft is possible and easy to implement. The line between tablets and laptops is blurring and we're seeing more and more hybrid devices and this is good news for those worrying about securing their device as GPS and internet access which means that these devices can at least be secured more easily now. Data security couldn't be easier in this day and age of “cloud” computing. Be sensible, use services such as Google drive, or Skydrive. Services like Flickr will give you 1TB of storage space and are ideal for backing up your gigabytes of images. Don't forget to configure its privacy settings before-hand though.